
Arsenal bottle it against Liverpool? Neville nonsense debunked

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Arsenal bottle it against Liverpool? Neville nonsense debunked

Mikel Arteta and Arne Slot were in agreement about Arsenal, Liverpool and magic moments. Gary Neville and Gabriel Martinelli gave us plenty more to go at.

Liverpool beat Arsenal 1-0 at Anfield thanks to a stunning Dominik Szoboszlai free-kick to help the champions enter the September international break top of [the Premier League table](#).

The Arsenal introspection was well underway into the game but could Arteta have done things differently? Or does that dilute Slot's excellence?

READ MORE: [Arsenal too respectful of Liverpool as Szoboszlai stunner, uninventive Arteta decide title clash](#)

1) Arsenal lost that game because Szoboszlai decided to thwack a free-kick in from 30 yards, not because they showed too much caution or risk aversion away at [the highest-spending-in-the-world-this-summer](#) reigning champions.

2) There is absolutely [a conversation to be had about Mikel Arteta's overall approach and his in-game decisions](#).

The inclusion of Mikel Merino summed up a starting line-up defined by its physicality – as if that came as any sort of surprise – while Eberechi Eze and Martin Odegaard could have been brought on a little sooner before the game began to drift from the visitors.

Maybe Viktor Gyokeres could have been deployed differently instead of being expected to roll two of the best centre-halves in the world as if he was playing Leeds or Estoril Praia.

But the idea it came down to a lack of courage, that Arsenal were too cautious while Liverpool were rewarded for a show of ambition, is patently nonsense.

Szoboszlai was remunerated for, as he himself put it, deciding to “take the risk”. But Liverpool in general gambled no more than Arsenal did.

These were just two brilliant teams who played differently and with immense respect for the opponent but with the same broad idea: countering the other team's strengths rather than trying to accentuate their few weaknesses.

3) Roy Keane obviously trotted out the “the sign of a really brilliant team is... winning football matches when you're not at your very best – that's what champions do”.

[Gary Neville stopped being able to accurately analyse Arsenal years ago](#) but two of his takes were egregious.

The idea that “if Arsenal want to win the league they need to go to Anfield and win”, or that Arne Slot's side have “that edge to go on and win those big matches” which the Gunners don't, is provable, tired, cliched nonsense.

A first defeat against a fellow Big Six side in 22 games dating back two and a half years told us nothing about Arsenal's mentality. It reinforced the sense that there really is precious little between these two teams and a remarkable free-kick alone might be needed to separate them on any given day.

4) But one thing is true: the longer it goes on, the more real the danger is that Arsenal's 'inability to win' at Anfield or the Etihad becomes a self-fulfilling prophecy.

Santi Cazorla scored in both of their most recent Premier League wins at either venue. While titles can, have and always will be won without beating the closest contender away from home, there is a baggage that comes with that for the players, coaches and staff over time.

A draw would have been an excellent result and the outcome-driven narrative should not cloud that. [But this Anfield curse has already made Arteta's head fall clean off before](#) so you fear what he might do next in search of those fine margins.

5) Saying Arsenal were not adventurous or purposeful enough also does Liverpool an immense disservice.

They reacted to their slight inferiority in the first half, made changes to their system and eventually personnel and provided the foundations which meant, as Arne Slot said, "a moment of magic" could sway the result in their favour.

The Dutchman explained how his alterations in matching Arsenal's man-for-man approach improved their midfield solidity, ignited their press and gave them a foothold in the game.

The focus will always be on the perceived weaknesses and shortcomings of the losing side in these fixtures but Slot deserves more credit for his reaction than Arteta does criticism for an apparent lack of proaction.

6) The key change was the introduction of Curtis Jones.

A phenomenal midfielder though Alexis Mac Allister is, the fitness issues which interrupted his pre-season have had a clear impact and there were times he was struggling to keep up with the intensity.

Ryan Gravenberch was handling the defensive duties in midfield well enough but there was no cohesive link to the attack.

Jones was perhaps an underwhelming first substitute but he addressed that issue quickly with better choices and execution in his passes and an ability to drive and carry from deep. That was how he won the Szoboszlai free-kick after a delightful turn in the centre circle left Martin Zubimendi stranded.

7) Arsenal's first unenforced substitutions came ten minutes after Jones was brought on. Eze and Odegaard were bright in moments but with the visitors no longer in the ascendancy their early objectives were more defensive in nature.

In the 15 minutes prior to them coming on, Arsenal had barely over 25 per cent possession. It was always going to be a difficult tide to turn.

Eze did get around his man once, when a clever touch took him past wonderful makeshift right-back Szoboszlai in stoppage time. But Joe Gomez was on immediate hand to clear the danger, covering his teammate impeccably.

[Liverpool have flirted with the idea of selling Gomez for years](#) but their ultimate reluctance is understandable. He and Mosquera were phenomenal in exacting circumstances because elite clubs now have better centre-halves on standby than most teams do starting.

8) Szoboszlai had not struggled to contain Gabriel Martinelli by the time the Brazilian was removed. Zero shots, zero chances created, 15 touches and six passes completed is an accurate depiction of an ineffective performance.

He led one counter-attack in the first half with two options in space on his right and Gyokeres in prime position to his left, aiming a run behind Konate, but Martinelli simply caught up with Swede, dribbled past him and ran the ball out of play.

[The “talent of the century” picked out by Jurgen Klopp](#) is a liability in this team.

9) There was a stark contrast on the other side with the far more decisive Noni Madueke, whose battle with Milos Kerkez was the most entertaining in the entire game.

No player won or lost. Madueke got the better of his man a couple of times with his speed and direct running, while Kerkez stood his ground and was never properly beaten in any meaningful way.

Arsenal and Liverpool fans will produce the exact same compilation of those performances and pretend their player was the clear victor, but in a match devoid of consistent quality throughout it was refreshing.

[That Madueke petition](#) presumably has no recent signatories either. It turns out he does precisely what was planned in helping diversify a stilted attack while providing depth.

10) About a minute after Eze and Odegaard entered, there was an absolutely stunning collective shout of “man on” from the entire stadium as the pressing Gyokeres bore down on a slight Szoboszlai hospital pass on the halfway line as Liverpool started to push forward.

Gravenberch had been preparing to take a touch to steady himself and consider his options but suddenly shifted his feet to offload the ball first time to Virgil van Dijk behind him.

Arsenal had been on the back foot for a while by then but Liverpool's position was still precarious. That helped them sustain the pressure. It was flawless from all involved.

11) Actually the worst thing Neville came out with was calling Szoboszlai's free-kick “Cristiano Ronaldo-like” despite it not crashing into the wall after an ultra close-up of him taking a performatively deep breath.

12) It was weird that Chris Kavanagh didn't blow for full time as soon as Wataru Endo came on. In a world where substitutes are increasingly referred to as ‘finishers’, few have embraced the term quite so beautifully.

That rugby tackle on Gyokeres to earn a yellow card in the seventh minute of stoppage time

summed up his role in this squad perfectly.

13) Gyokeres himself was actually fine and the main problem remains Arsenal adjusting to him rather than the other way around.

A few of his trademark runs were simply not seen by players used to making a different kind of pass. The Martinelli example cited earlier was glaring but in general Arsenal failed to use him properly. The sight of Gyokeres crossing into a crowded area in the final minutes encapsulated the issue.

But perhaps this was the idea behind his signing all along. Gyokeres failed to have a single shot against either Manchester United or Liverpool but [scored twice against Leeds](#). It is just an awful lot to spend on a flat-track bully.

14) Arsenal reducing a game of such magnitude to fine margins was neither surprising nor particularly wrong. That blueprint has garnered positive results before and the way Arteta spoke after the game did not indicate there would be a change going forward.

But it was a different way for Liverpool to win, especially in the embryonic context of this season. A 1-0 grind bore no resemblance to those rollercoaster 4-2 and 3-2 victories in which the mere concept of defending was cast aside.

It augurs well for the champions that they have already shown myriad feathers in their bow. They just adjust to the demands of each individual game impeccably.

15) It had to be Van Dijk with the final touch, an authoritative headed full stop up against four different Arsenal players in the Liverpool box.

The captain made some stunning passes from deep, at one stage pressed an Arsenal player so high he was on the edge of their area and then seamlessly transitioned into a more backs-against-the-wall defensive leader role to guide them through.

It was exceptional from what remains even at 34 one of the best defenders in the world.

16) And just imagine if Liverpool add a lethal goalscorer to this intriguing mix of players and skillsets. Marc Guehi in this team feels unfair.

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